

BROWNFIELD LAB

Project 3 — Maintaining a Brownfield Repository

The AI is only as good as the context you give it, and you control the context.

BEFORE YOU START

Before you start.

 5 MIN

- ✓ Pick your repo: yours, or a fallback (eShopOnWeb for .NET, hexo for Node) — start the agent inside that folder.
- ✓ Cut a branch: `git checkout -b brownfield-lab`
- ✓ Own repo → push it: `git push -u origin brownfield-lab`. Fallback → keep the branch local (or fork first).
- ✓ Fallback prereqs: .NET 8 SDK, or Node 20.19+.

PART 1 • THE WRONG WAY

Just build it.

 10 MIN

- ✓ Start the agent inside the repo folder
- ✓ Paste Prompt 1 — no planning, no context, default model
- ✓ Let it run. Don't fix anything.
- ✓ Then: did it build? Did it run? Did you see it work?

PROMPT 1

TRANSITION

Now do it right.

✓ `git add -A`

✓ `git stash push -m "wrong-way attempt"`

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STEP 1 · MAP THE CODEBASE

Map the codebase.

 10 MIN

- ✓ Fresh session, in the repo folder
- ✓ Prompt 2 → save as ARCHITECTURE.md
- ✓ Skim it as it writes. Correct what's wrong — that's context.

Full version: the cartographer plugin. Run it on your real repo tonight.

PROMPT 2

Get it building and running.

🕒 10–20 MIN

- ✓ Same session
- ✓ Prompt 3 — real output only, no summaries
- ✓ Record the working commands in ARCHITECTURE.md
- ✓ Brought your own repo? This may be the whole lab — that's fine.

PROMPT 3

Create specialized agents.

🕒 10 MIN

- ✓ Fresh session
- ✓ Prompt 4 → `.claude/agents/`: front-end, back-end, others only if real
- ✓ CLAUDE.md, under 60 lines
- ✓ Delete anything generic

PROMPT 4

STEP 4 • THE RETRO HABIT

What did we learn?

 5 MIN

- ✓ Same session, before you close it
- ✓ Prompt 5 — put it where it belongs
- ✓ Then `/clear`

PROMPT 5

STEP 5 · PLAN THE FEATURE

Plan with a stronger model.

 15 MIN

- ✓ Switch to Opus. Enter plan mode.
- ✓ Prompt 6 — tell it your background
- ✓ Orchestrator + Sonnet subagents do; Opus researches
- ✓ Plan → docs/plans/<feature>.md, handoff prompt on top

PROMPT 6

Execute the plan.

🕒 20–30 MIN

- ✓ `/clear`, then paste the handoff prompt
- ✓ Prompt 7 — stay on the powerful model, as orchestrator
- ✓ “Not done until it runs locally and I can see it.”
- ✓ Watch how it delegates.

PROMPT 7

Show and tell.

- ✓ Open your feature. Show your neighbors.
- ✓ Compare: `git stash show -p`
- ✓ Same request — what was different?

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